

CANONICAL LESSON

Evaluate Programmes, Not Just Scores

Decision-centred foundations for accountable sector intelligence

Production Unit	PU-B07-C49
Notebook	V7_C_N14
Status	Controlled educational draft v0.1
Data boundary	Synthetic instructional data only

Central decision: Evaluate education programmes using explicit theory, counterfactual logic, implementation evidence, outcomes, equity, costs, uncertainty, and decision relevance.

Learning outcomes

Why this matters

Before-and-after scores can misattribute change and encourage scaling a programme that was ineffective, unequal, or poorly implemented.

The analytical workflow is useful only when evidence, uncertainty, authority, and action are connected explicitly. The model supports professional judgement; it does not replace accountable institutional authority.

Worked cross-sector example

An evaluation separates score change from plausible programme contribution and checks who benefited, at what cost, and under which conditions.

Boundary: The example supports learning and review. It does not constitute an official statistic, eligibility determination, enforcement action, clinical judgement, or operational authorization.

Practice and reflection

- 1.
- Account for school clustering.
- 2.
- Distinguish statistical and educational importance.
- 3.

- Audit heterogeneous effects.

Answer key

- 1.
- Randomization and inference must respect the school or assigned cluster.
- 2.
- A precise small score change may not matter educationally; compare against meaningful benchmarks and costs.
- 3.
- Pre-specify subgroups, report uncertainty, avoid deficit labels, and investigate implementation and access.

Operational readiness checklist

- Purpose and decision owner are named.
- Evidence definitions, provenance, and lawful access are documented.
- Uncertainty and abstention are visible.
- Human review, escalation, monitoring, incident response, and retirement are assigned.
- Equity, accessibility, security, and sector-specific approval are complete.